



Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

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Let's Start!

Mercury retrograde affects everyone and everything!



Learning Outcome

Exchange information about hypothetical situations in written and spoken interactions according to work and social contexts.

Can Do Statements

- I can discuss coincidences and strange events.
- I can express and report opinions and beliefs.
- I can speculate about the past with different degrees of certainty.

Ask your partner:

- When have you not taken advice from someone and later regretted it? What happened?
- What kinds of things can affect how someone behaves?

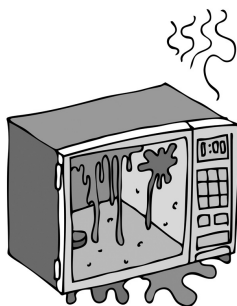




Let's Explore!

Vanessa has to **eat her words***

* If you "eat your words", you take back what you said or admit that what you said was wrong.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

- Peter:** Hello?
- Vanessa:** Hey Peter. How are you?
- Peter:** I'm great. How about you?
- Vanessa:** Well ... I'm not sure. Ummm ... is Mercury in retrograde right now?
- Peter:** Yes, it is. The retrograde lasts for about three weeks so we have a couple more days to go. Why do you ask?
- Vanessa:** Well, I started thinking about what's been happening lately and I think the retrograde could have affected me after all.
- Peter:** Really? So you believe me?
- Vanessa:** Well, in the last two weeks a number of things have gone wrong. After you talked about the magnetic effect on electronic equipment, I recalled that my internet got really slow and my laptop was doing strange things. Also, my microwave oven went kaput. That can't all have been a coincidence. It must have been caused by the Mercury retrograde.
- Peter:** It's likely that if we weren't in Mercury retrograde, all of that wouldn't have happened at the same time.
- Vanessa:** Also, you mentioned that it affects personal communication. I hired a new staff member last week. She signed a 3-month contract with me but I think she may not work out. She claimed that she had lots of experience but I'm beginning to doubt her. I explained that she would have to work weekends but now she's saying that she can't.
- Peter:** Yeah, that could have been a bad idea. You don't want to embark on anything new if Mercury is in retrograde. If people do and say things that are out of character during this time, you have to take them with a grain of salt.
- Vanessa:** I should have taken this more seriously. You recommend that I not make any changes during the retrograde but I didn't heed your warning. Now I think I'm paying the price.





Let's Practice!

Vanessa thinks she should have followed Peter's advice, but she didn't.

Instructions: Match the statements from Column A to the ones on Column B. Read the complete sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

COLUMN A

1. That can't all have been
2. It's likely that if we weren't in Mercury retrograde,
3. All of that wouldn't have happened
4. Yeah, that could have been
5. It must have been caused

COLUMN B

- a. things would have been better.
- b. a coincidence.
- c. at the same time.
- d. a bad idea.
- e. by the Mercury retrograde.



Let's Practice!

Vanessa finally realizes that it's all Mercury's fault.

Instructions: Use the options from the Word Bank to correctly complete the sentences. Read the complete sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.

Word Bank

I explained / You mentioned that / She claimed that / You were /
You recommended that / I claimed / She mentioned / She was

- 1) _____ it affects personal communication.
- 2) _____ she had lots of experience but I'm beginning to doubt her.
- 3) _____ that she would have to work weekends but now she's saying that she can't.
- 4) _____ I not make any changes during the retrograde but I didn't heed your warning.
- 5) _____ very clear about the influence of the planets on our life, and now I think I'm paying the price.



Extension Activity

Write a story about eating your words.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Think about a time that you had to eat your words (admit that what you said was wrong).
- Write a story about the situation.
- If you can't think of a true story you can make one up.
- Read your story aloud to your class or group.
- Decide together who had the funniest, most embarrassing or craziest story.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I write a story about when I was wrong.

☐ ☐

I read my story to a group.

☐ ☐

I listen to other students' stories.

☐ ☐

I decide on the funniest, most embarrassing or craziest story with my group.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- to embark** (verb): begin
e.g. You don't want to embark on anything new if Mercury is in retrograde.
- out of character** (expression): inconsistent with usual patterns of behaviour
e.g. If people do and say things that are out of character during this time, you have to take them with a grain of salt.
- to doubt** (verb): to feel uncertain
e.g. She claimed that she had lots of experience but I'm beginning to doubt her.
- magnetic** (adjective): attracting by the properties of a magnet
e.g. You talked about the magnetic effect on electronic equipment.
- to recall** (verb): to bring the memory of a past event into your mind
e.g. I recalled that my internet got really slow and my laptop was doing strange things.
- to go kaput** (expression): to no longer work or be effective
e.g. My microwave oven went kaput.
- to heed** (verb): to pay attention to advice or warnings
e.g. You recommended that I not make any changes during the retrograde but I didn't heed your warning.
- to pay the price** (expression): suffering the consequences of one's actions
e.g. Now I think I'm paying the price.





Learning Points

That-Clauses: With or Without Personal Objects

After some verbs, you can use a *that*-clause with or without a personal object before that. If you do include an object, you need to add a preposition before it.

For example:

*She **admitted (to me)** **that** she stole the bag.*

*I **pointed out (to the tour guide)** **that** we missed the turn.*

Use these verbs in the same way: *announce, complain, confess, explain, indicate, mention, propose, recommend, report, say, suggest.*

After some verbs, you use *with*.

For example:

*We **agreed (with James)** **that** the information should be kept secret.*

Use these verbs in the same way: *argue, check, disagree, joke.*

Examples:

- *You mentioned that it affects personal communication.*
- *She claimed that she had lots of experience but I'm beginning to doubt her.*
- *I explained that she would have to work weekends but now she's saying that she can't.*
- *You recommended that I not make any changes during the retrograde but I didn't heed your warning.*

Speculating About the Past with Different Degrees of Certainty

You make decisions and conclusions using the information that is available to you. You may be more or less certain of your conclusion depending on this information. You can use different modals to indicate how certain your conclusion is.

If you have strong evidence, and are fairly certain about actions that occurred in the past, you use **must have** and **couldn't have** plus the past participle of the verb.

When you speculate that something did happen, you use *must have + past participle*.

For example:

*Nancy has a tan - she **must have traveled** to a warm and sunny place.*

When you speculate that something did not happen, you use *must not have + past participle*.





Learning Points

For example:

*He **must not have cleaned** his room because there is still laundry everywhere!*

When you speculate that something was possible but you are less certain, you use *could have + past participle*.

When you speculate that something was impossible, you use *can't have + past participle* or *could not have + past participle*.

For example:

*Jessica **couldn't have taken** your bag - she wasn't even here today!*

When you want to talk about something that didn't happen, but you want to imagine that it did, you can use *would (not) have + past participle*.

For example:

It's likely that if we weren't in Mercury retrograde, all of that wouldn't have happened at the same time.

Examples:

- *I think the retrograde could have affected me after all.*
- *That can't all have been a coincidence.*
- *It must have been caused by the Mercury retrograde.*
- *That could have been a bad idea.*
- *If we weren't in Mercury retrograde, all of that wouldn't have happened at the same time.*

